reset. But there are clues to show that a major showdown in the Cabinet was in the offing – for which the letter was only an opening act.

On 10 November, US Ambassador Loy Henderson cabled Secretary of State Dean Acheson, noting that he had reliable and authoritative information that events in Tibet had resulted in increasing dissatisfaction within the government with the direction of India's foreign policy – and that even Nehru's supporters had recognized the threat posed by international communism and the need for a shift in policy.[63] 'Patel has been stating privately,' he continued, 'that within the next few days he will insist in [the] Cabinet meeting that India not only change policy in direction of closer cooperation with Western powers, particularly US, but that it make an announcement to that effect.'[64] Patel was reported to have said privately that he had been willing to defer to Nehru in matters of foreign policy so long as India's security was not at stake; but could not remain passive when the continuation of Nehru's policy would endanger the nation's security.

As Henderson relayed, the deputy prime minister 'felt so strongly in the matter that he would prefer to resign from Cabinet and to break openly with Nehru than to allow matters to drift'.[65] In a showdown with the Prime Minister, Patel believed he could count on the strong support of Rajagopalachari, K.M. Munshi, Baldev Singh, Jagjivan Ram and Sri Prakasa while he expected Nehru to be backed by Maulana Azad, Gopalswami Ayyangar and Rafi Ahmed Kidwai.[66] It is likely that Ambedkar, given his views, would also have lined up behind Patel. In fact, Ambassador Henderson believed Nehru to be almost the only person in the government who still believed in friendship with communist China and argued that India should make no move that might endanger that friendship.[67] Patel also had the option of challenging Nehru in the Congress Working Committee,[68] where his supporters enjoyed a clear preponderance.

An embattled Prime Minister had a note prepared for the Cabinet on 18 November as a response to his critics, where he laid out his case for continuing friendship with China: India lacked the capacity to help Tibet, it should not sponsor a Tibetan appeal in the United Nations because it would